

China: April activity data preview: Expecting slightly faster industrial production and retail sales growth, but weaker investment

Bottom line:

China's April activity data are scheduled for release next Monday (18 May). We expect industrial production (IP) growth to rebound to 6.2% yoy in April from 5.7% yoy in March, as stronger-than-expected exports, a narrower year-on-year contraction in steel demand, and an improvement in automobile output growth indicate modestly better manufacturing sector momentum despite the global energy-supply shock. We expect year-on-year fixed asset investment (FAI) growth to slow further to 1.1% in April from 1.6% in March on a single-month basis, reflecting a dip in the NBS construction PMI, a notable contraction in policy bank net financing and heavy rainfalls in southern China. Our forecast implies year-to-date FAI growth would be 1.5% yoy in April. Retail sales growth may rise slightly to 2.0% yoy in April from 1.7% yoy in March, as higher energy prices may have boosted gasoline sales value growth and the nationwide promotion of spring breaks this year may have frontloaded some dining-out demand to April from May, despite still-subdued automobile and home appliance sales growth. Our April activity data forecasts are slightly above market consensus for IP, largely in line for retail sales, but slightly below for FAI.

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Main points:

China's April activity data – including industrial production (IP), fixed asset investment (FAI), and retail sales – are scheduled for release next Monday (18 May). We provide our preview below ([Exhibit 1](#)):

- We expect IP growth to rebound to 6.2% yoy in April from 5.7% yoy in March, as stronger-than-expected exports, a narrower year-on-year contraction in steel demand, and an improvement in automobile output growth indicate modestly better manufacturing sector momentum despite the global energy-supply shock. Our forecast implies that IP may have gained 4.6% mom sa annualized in April (vs. +5.1% mom sa annualized in March), in line with what solid manufacturing PMIs suggest.
- We expect year-on-year FAI growth to slow further to 1.1% in April from 1.6% in March on a single-month basis, reflecting a dip in the NBS construction PMI, a notable contraction in policy bank net financing (through the PBOC's Pledged Supplementary Lending and policy bank bond issuance) and heavy rainfalls in southern China (which may have constrained some outdoor construction activity). Our China Commodities research team's channel check also suggests that end-user orderbooks for most basic materials softened as of mid-April. Our

forecast implies year-to-date FAI growth would be 1.5% yoy in April (vs. 1.7% yoy in March).

- Retail sales growth may rise slightly to 2.0% yoy in April from 1.7% yoy in March, as higher energy prices may have boosted gasoline sales value growth, and the nationwide promotion of spring breaks this year (in late April) may have frontloaded some dining-out demand to April from May. These factors should have more than offset still-subdued automobile and home appliance sales growth, which reflects weakening effectiveness of the ongoing consumer goods trade-in program.

Our April activity data forecasts are slightly above market consensus for IP, largely in line for retail sales, but slightly below for FAI.

Exhibit 1: GS forecasts vs. consensus for April activity data

Date and Time (BJT)	Indicator	Period	GS Forecast	Bloomberg Consensus	Prior (Mar)
18 May (Mon), 10:00	Industrial Production	Apr	6.2	5.9	5.7
	Fixed Asset Investment (year-to-date)	Apr	1.5	1.7	1.7
	Retail Sales	Apr	2.0	1.9	1.7

Numbers refer to year-on-year growth rates in the reporting period.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Bloomberg

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